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Contents

[English text unavailable] 2
[English text unavailable] 5
[English text unavailable] 6
[English text unavailable] 6
[English text unavailable] 10

[English text unavailable]

COL-900001

Laplace Researcher: 77 114 46 32 85 108 114 105 99 104?

Laplace Researcher: 84 104 101 114 101 39 115 32 97 32 102 111 120 32 104 101 114 101 32 116 111 32 115 101 101 32 121 111 117.

The researcher steps into the room, surprised to see so many people inside.

He gives polite nods to them—Enigma, Hissabeth, Medicine Pocket, Mr. APPLe, though not a researcher himself, always at Regulus's side, and a woman wearing a Foundation badge—then waits quietly for Ulrich to respond.

Ulrich looks up from his stack of reports.

Ulrich: ... Pardon?

Laplace Researcher: 79104!

The researcher's eyes widen for a moment, then he quickly pulls a device from his pocket and recites a string of long numbers into it.

Ulrich: ...

After a short pause, an artificial voice speaks from the device.

Translator: Sorry, Mr. Ulrich. I forgot to switch the translator on. There's a strange fox-headed character asking for you.

Ulrich: Oh no, it was my mistake. Damn report's got me stuck thinking in octal. I didn't realize you were using decimal.

Ulrich gives a wave of his hand, as if brushing the numbers away.

Ulrich: Must be Musae III. We're on our way.

The code-speaking researcher leaves the room.

Enigma, who had maintained a mocking expression through the whole scene, now sees no reason to hold back his thoughts any longer.

Enigma: Three minutes. Remarkable. Thanks to your "great compassion" in the toybox, we're now communicating as efficiently as early primates. At this rate, we might graduate from meaningless shouting to cave paintings within the week.

Ulrich: Let's get one thing straight. This has nothing to do with my humanitarian efforts.

The ferrofluid flickers with irritation as he is forced once again to brush off the same accusations Enigma has been throwing at him since his return.

Ulrich: In fact, if I hadn't cracked that lock on the beach, we'd still have no clue about the toybox malfunction, let alone where this damn language disorder came from.

Two researchers, who clearly have no real reason to be in the room, exchange a glance.

Clearly, they'd rather be involved in this "project" than stuck trying to communicate with colleagues who only speak in numbers and codes.

Medicine Pocket: Ugh, not this again.

Hissabeth: If we count that fight right after they came out of the toybox, this makes it the eighth time. Just stay quiet and enjoy.

Enigma: Maybe if you'd focused on the actual project instead of worrying about those pieces,

Enigma: you could've returned the toybox before it unleashed all its miseries on the world, Mr. Pandora.

Ulrich: Quit joking around! The language disorder is getting worse by the hour.

Ulrich: Owen—the one who brought the message just now—still understands English, but Hannah's only been able to read Hill cipher symbols since yesterday afternoon. How can you be so sure it's not going to get worse?

Enigma: If you'd just stop wasting time on those silly simulations, we could shorten the Pre-Storm Protocol by at least thirty percent.

Enigma: Assuming all the coded language swimming around in that glass tank of yours hasn't completely scrambled your circuits!

Ulrich: Assuming YOU'RE capable of being useful for once rather than only throwing out smug comments!

Another argument breaks out, but before it can go any further, a quiet yet steady voice speaks up.

Marcus: Sir ... Sirs ...

Marcus: I hate to interrupt, but did you say language disorder?

Ulrich turns away, struggling to steady his turbulent emotions, pretending he doesn't hear Hissabeth heave a regretful sigh.

Ulrich: Correct, Ms. Marcus. For the last four days, communication at Laplace has completely broken down. People are speaking in binary code, Morse code, even rail fence cipher. Almost everyone has switched to encrypted languages.

Ulrich: We think it's linked to the toybox we've been using for our Pre-Storm Protocol stimulations.

Ulrich: During the inspection last week, Musae III mentioned something was stolen. After that, the language disorder started spreading fast from the floor we keep the toybox on, and it hasn't let up since.

Ulrich: While we haven't seen any other effects beyond the communication problems so far ...

Marcus looks nervous.

Marcus: Are you concerned this could ... cause time disturbances?

Hissabeth: Oh please, don't panic. It's not going to trigger a "Storm" inside Laplace or anything.

Hissabeth: But it will absolutely wreck our weekly briefings, lab funding applications, and the canteen's ordering system.

Hissabeth: In other words, it'll throw off Laplace's whole schedule.

Marcus: I'm just wondering ... how can I help? Codes and math aren't really my strengths ...

Enigma: Didn't you manage to write down that incantation from "The Circle"?

Enigma: You were able to push past physical barriers and understand the real meaning directly. That's your arcane skill, isn't it?

Ulrich: Our current issue is also about language, mathematical as it may be. Your skills in picking out hidden messages might just be exactly what we need.

Marcus: Understood. I'll do the best I can.

Ulrich gives a small nod, pleased to see even a brief moment of calm, focused discussion.

Ulrich: Musae III is already looking into it. Let's go; we need to confirm our next steps.

Musae III: I'll keep working to fix the toybox and try my best to slow down the language corruption. But ... I'm afraid I'll have to ask you to go back inside it again.

Enigma: You can't be serious.

Enigma glares at the two-headed fox plushie, his voice brimming with disbelief.

Musae III: This time it's different, my friends.

Musae III: The core of the toybox is gone, yes, but it hasn't left the system. I'm certain it's still in there somewhere, just not where it should be.

Musae III: There's a high chance—higher than ninety percent—that it's moved to the program layer, and that means it's deeper inside the toybox.

Enigma: Wait a second, whiskers. Be clear—what exactly are we supposed to find? A piece? A component?

Musae III: Well ... that's the tricky part. I don't really know how to describe what it looks like.

Musae III: From what I can tell, the toybox's cognitive systems aren't functioning as they should. Simply put, it might not have a fixed or familiar shape now.

Musae III: But not to worry! Just as a corrupted language still functions as a language, the core should still hold its basic cognitive properties. Perhaps you'll notice its shifting forms follow some kind of logic ...

Even though Musae III speaks with all the soothing skills of both a businessman and a stuffed animal, neither Ulrich nor Enigma seems any more relaxed.

Enigma: So what you're saying is we're hunting a "Proteus" with almost no leads?

Musae III: Precisely, my friend! I only wish I had some sealskins to give you. Ah, before I forget, if the language in Laplace has become this bad, things inside the toybox are probably even worse.

Musae III: Do you still have a translator?

Everyone turns to look at APPLe, whose long silence now feels less like a gentleman's politeness and more like someone caught in an awkward situation.

APPLe: ... I ... I has last wun.

Musae III: Interesting! He's speaking like one of those little black fuzzy creatures. I suppose Critter communication does qualify as some kind of symbolic system.

The apple's skin has never looked so red. He quickly hands the translator to Ulrich.

APPLe: Please, help this APPLe soon, my friend.

The ferrofluid trembles deeply in its tank—probably the equivalent to a deep breath for a human—in an attempt to stay calm.

Ulrich: Alright then. Translators, a "Proteus," language and cognitive disorders ... Sounds just like the chaos before the "Storm," but at least now I know how to deal with the pieces.

Ulrich: I'm ready.

Enigma: No. I'M ready.

Enigma steps forward, a dark look on his face.

Enigma: Considering how humanitarianism seems to overtake you at the worst possible times, it's safer if I handle it this time.

[English text unavailable]

COL-900002

Enigma: So the whole of Laplace can't figure out how to fix this ridiculous box problem once and for all?

Medicine Pocket: Quit your whining, Adler. Got a letter for you.

Enigma: For me? This just looks like a piece of regular Laplace calculation paper. What makes you think it's for me?

Medicine Pocket: One, it was shoved into YOUR door. Two, there's a big "READ IT" written on it in black ink.

Medicine Pocket rolls their eyes at having to yet again spell things out.

Medicine Pocket: Honestly, who does something like that unless it's some kind of complaint?

Enigma unfolds what looks like a piece of regular Laplace calculation paper, but what's on it is clearly far from ordinary.

Enigma: No name on it. They're proposing construction of some ... tower. A tower to standardize all linguistic systems inside the toybox.

Hissabeth: Sounds like something from a detective novel. Hey, Adler—sorry for eavesdropping. But besides us, who else knows about the missing core?

Enigma: Perfect. Our security protocols might as well be town crier announcements.

Medicine Pocket: It's gotta be Institutum Lorentz. They must've sniffed out info on our little "arcane accident" somehow.

Enigma: As suspicious an institution as they are, their idea is theoretically feasible. Creating a unified language system, no matter what it is, would solve all our problems.

Ulrich: But what would Lorentz gain by helping us? Ms. Marcus, are you able to glean any information from this note?

Enigma passes it to her.

Marcus looks down at the small piece of paper. Normally, words are easy for her to gather information from, but now ...

Marcus: Hmm ...

Her brow furrows.

Marcus: The handwriting is very precise, almost like a machine—typical of a perfectionist, or someone who likes order ...

Marcus: Yet the uneven pressure almost suggests some carelessness, which, well, contradicts my initial assessment ...

Marcus: The writing's purpose seems to be ... purposeless? Like they're just random ink marks ... That can't be correct. I ... I can't make sense of this ...

Enigma: Clearly, they're suffering from the same language disorder. Either they're rushing to fix it, or —

Medicine Pocket: Whenever something even slightly connects to the "Storm," they show up in swarms like Critters. I guess even a simulated version counts to them, especially now that it's obviously showing anomalies.

Enigma: Regardless, our task now is to build a massive tower inside that box to somehow get everyone to speak the same language. Amazing.

It seems another trip into the toybox will be necessary. At least, this time, they know exactly what needs to be done.

Ulrich: I'll be sure to offer support from the outside, Researcher Adler.

Enigma: The best "support" you can offer us now is to get us all hard hats, since we'll all be in a construction zone soon.

Enigma: Oh, and make sure to get an extra-extra-large one for yourself to fit over that fish tank of yours.

[English text unavailable]

COL-900003

???: They actually pulled it off. I thought they'd fail and seal it away. Next time, I'll need to be more subtle with the clues.

???: Now then ... how should I explain this in my report to Lorentz?

[English text unavailable]

COL-900004

In the "Toybox"

Ulrich: Wait a second, Researcher Regulus.

Ulrich: You say you're planning to do ... what now?

Regulus: Complete my 232nd and 233rd weekly performance indicators, obvs.

Regulus: You see, I've got to finish my report on "Applications of Optical Arcane Skills in Architectural Defense Systems," then meet with 37 in exactly five hours to discuss launching a universal algebraic geometry curriculum.

Regulus: This is the third time you've asked me this, Mr. Ulrich. This some kind of new employee evaluation protocol?

Regulus: Can't believe I'm saying so, but I think I prefer the logic puzzles and mathematical riddles.

Ulrich: Evaluation? Logic? Riddles?

Ulrich: Researcher Regulus?!

Ulrich: But you said you found them all, what was it, "a crushing bore"?

Regulus: A bore? Hadn't we reached a consensus—

Regulus: There's nothing more rockin' in the world than thorough mathematical analysis!

Office

The report is nearly complete. Only the final line of conclusions remains blank.

Agitated, the ferrofluid inside his head flickers rapidly. He picks up his pen, then sets it down again.

???: Mr. Ulrich?

The cheerful young man pushes the door open and enters with light steps, realizing too late that he's interrupted Ulrich's train of thought.

X: Sorry. Are you busy? I can come back later.

Ulrich: No, I've been staring at this pile of paper long enough. Perhaps if I leave it alone long enough, it'll absorb some part of my arcane energy and become an Awakened that can write itself.

X blinks with interest.

X: On that particular topic, I think I remember someone in the biotechnology team once tried to create an Awakened that was entirely devoted to "loving work," but they abandoned the project after concluding that you were already the prime specimen.

X: I'd personally recommend exercising judicious foresight before reviving that particular study. Especially concerning you, Mr. Ulrich, it could trigger some extremely complex ethical questions between Awakened.

X: Still, I empathize with the sentiment. Is the Pre-Storm research hitting a wall?

Ulrich: You could say that. But I'm not authorized to say more. I hope you understand.

X: Oh, actually, that's precisely why I'm here. I'm joining your team. So, you don't need to dissemble any secrets from me.

X: My application.

X hands him the document.

Ulrich: Pre-Storm Wandering Device ... Interactive Communication System Follow-Up Research?

X: That's right. While you were in Antarctica, Medicine Pocket and I gave the toybox a little "version upgrade."

X: It can now pick up items other players drop during their runs, and it lets everyone share gameplay strategies.

Ulrich: Hey! This is a research project, not some entertainment facility you can patch whenever you feel like it.

X: Of course, allow me to rephrase: out of rigorous scientific methodology and the goal of improving device efficiency, this system allows testers to contribute sample data during their personal recreation time.

X: Anyway, I think this interactive system has real potential and merits further investigation. That's why I submitted a collaboration proposal to Mr. Enigma, and it's already been approved.

X: So, what's going on with your Pre-Storm research?

Ulrich: After I got back from Antarctica, I checked the interior of the toybox. Since the Language Tower was finished, things have changed in there.

Ulrich slides the report across the table toward X.

X: "In recent simulations, a complete 'Storm' response protocol has formed within the Pre-Storm Wandering Device, capable of efficiently executing risk prevention and preliminary response measures with zero casualties."

X: "During the observation period, with no external interference, the success rate for weathering the 'Storm' within the device has reached 100%."

X: Hmm. The data looks impeccable.

X: This report should be thorough enough to capture the attention of the higher-ups. What's still bothering you?

Ulrich: The raven—Ludwig's piece—established a new order inside, and everyone else's thinking seems to have been influenced by the new order and the Language Tower.

Ulrich: Can you imagine? I encountered a Regulus who loved mathematics instead of Dr. Papper, a Windsong who abandoned the study of ley lines to focus on arcane material research, and a Medicine Pocket who hadn't chewed through a single piece of lab equipment.

Ulrich: Everything progresses smoothly according to indicators and schedules. Every employee strictly follows orders from above, devotes all their energy to research, and works at maximum efficiency.

X: So, everyone is committed to their research and behaves rationally? It seems a little far-fetched, I admit. Though I thought you'd welcome a more orderly and efficient Laplace?

Ulrich falls silent.

X shrugs and sets the report back down.

X: I'm just here to coordinate on the collaboration. I don't have clearance to interfere with the research, Mr. Ulrich.

X: Personally, I hope your project goes well. Just consider it a colleague's private well-wishes.

X leaves. The document lies open on the table, turned to its final page.

Ulrich: ...

Ulrich picks up the pen and writes down his final conclusion.

Ulrich: However, for reasons unknown, all participants have adopted behavior patterns prioritizing efficiency and results above all else, exhibiting a worrisome lack of humanity and increasingly mechanized thinking.

Ulrich: In conclusion, immediate implementation of this *Pre-Storm Protocol* is not recommended. The feasibility of this Protocol requires further evaluation.

Conference Room

Musae III: So, this is Mr. Ulrich's perspective.

Musae III: But Mr. Enigma has a different view.

Hissabeth: You're putting it nicely.

Medicine Pocket: All of that yelling he did at Ulrich was pretty disruptive, if entertaining.

X: It's humorous to hear Medicine Pocket of all people use the word "disruptive."

Their conversation has drawn in more than they initially expected.

Enigma pinches the bridge of his nose and turns around.

Enigma: Why are you all still here?

Hissabeth: That's a good question. X, why are you here?

X: Because I've formally submitted my application to Mr. Enigma, "Ms. Volunteer."

Hissabeth: Hmph. "Volunteer" perfectly reflects we Melusines' natural generosity and selfless spirit. Some of us don't need any incentive to help advance scientific progress.

Medicine Pocket: Oh yeah, that reminds me I need to clock my overtime hours.

Hissabeth: Or redirect it to our research budget. "Volunteer" members should get their own special allocations. Reasonable, n'est-ce pas?

Snake I: Agreed! Besides, Two already read that report ages ago. We really should already count as being on the team.

Ulrich catches on to something from the snake's statement.

Ulrich: You read the report? When?

Having accidentally stirred up trouble, the little snake retreats into Hissabeth's blue-green hair.

Hissabeth, slightly flustered, points a finger outward.

Hissabeth: Medicine Pocket also read it.

Ulrich: What? Why—

Ulrich: Speaking of which, who gave my report to Adler? I haven't even submitted it yet.

Medicine Pocket: I needed the latest data to tune the toybox's interactive system. Hey, you're the one who doesn't know how to lock your office door properly.

Ulrich: That's impossible. So you read it and then submitted it to Adler?

Medicine Pocket: Who has time for that? I just left it ...

They hesitate and chew on the ID card.

Hissabeth: In the pot by your office window, we think.

Hissabeth: Alexandre spotted it when he went out to play. Ever since he learned there was a shape-shifting snake inside the toybox, he's been obsessed with anything related to it.

Hissabeth: By the way, that window ledge has zero security. You really must put it somewhere less accessible.

Ulrich: How many people, including snakes, have read my report?!

Hissabeth: Well, of course, we Melusines share consciousness between all our snakes. But aside from that, we promise we haven't told anyone else.

X: As you know, I read it during my last visit, Mr. Ulrich.

X and Hissabeth show identical meek, polite smiles.

Enigma: Enough.

The substitute director frowns and cuts off the spiraling accusations.

Enigma: Regardless, I've read the report, and I disagree with Ulrich.

Enigma: We'll enter the box again, submit separate reports, and try to solve that core problem of yours, Mr. Fox.

Musae III: That's wonderful news, dear friends!

Both of Musae III's heads display cheerful expressions, totally unaware of the chaos around them.

Musae III: I also happen to have excellent news.

Musae III: I've brought the sealskin you need!

Enigma: Sealskin? The key to capturing Proteus, the shape-shifting god?

Musae III: Spot on, old chap!

Musae III: "Don the sealskin and seize that shape-shifting god, be he snake, rooster, tree, or flowing water." That's how the story goes, right?

Musae III: Once you obtain the core, this stabilization device will cause it to adopt a single stable form.

Musae III: That way, you needn't have to worry about losing it again through distraction or having those dizzying transformations scramble your brains!

Enigma: It can scramble our brains?

Musae III: Not anymore! I can practically guarantee that.

The fox plushie adjusts the toybox with a smile, his tone as inviting as it is oddly sinister.

Musae III: So, friends, who'd like to do the honors?

[English text unavailable]

COL-900005

The tower collapses.

In the "Toybox"

The crowd roars behind them, as the newly freed employees begin letting out their usual cheers.

The raven crashes to the ground, staggers in uneven circles twice, then starts flapping its wings.

Ulrich: Hey! Crazy raven! Adler!

Enigma reacts quickly this time.

He lunges forward and catches the bird before it can fly away.

The bird piece tumbles beneath the cylindrical human's, struggling to escape the grip of two stick arms.

Neither piece can move freely. The struggle continues.

Enigma: Ulrich—come—help!

Ulrich: Stacking another cylinder on top will accomplish nothing besides making this look even more like a circus act.

Enigma: X says—he's detecting—abnormal—data fluctuations—

Enigma: At least figure out—

Ulrich: Watch out!

Don't linger in front of a crumbling wall, much less a collapsing tower. Everyone should remember that.

A metal rod falls and strikes the raven on the head.

Crow Piece: Gah!

...

Ulrich: Is he dead?

Enigma: No. Likely concussed, but alive.

Enigma: No, wait, he ...

Enigma rises from the floor, revealing the other piece's appearance.

His limp body stiffens as his wings spread in a sharp unnatural pose as if struck by a Stono Swift, or ...

Reverting to an unconscious, immobile, genuine game piece.

Ulrich: Is this a bug? The pieces in the box have never taken this form.

Enigma: X?

X's voice drifts down from overhead.

X: I'm here. The abnormal arcane fluctuation has dissipated.

Enigma: We'll deal with that later. We must secure the core first.

They turn their attention back to the tower.

Under their gaze, the collapsed tower, along with that metal rod, transforms together into a stack of research reports.

Ulrich: My report? No, it's the Equilibrium Umbrella. Medicine Pocket's plant, or a hamster ball. Why a hamster ball?

Enigma: Don't stare at it!

Various forms melt and reshape themselves before their eyes.

Fighting through the throbbing pain in his temples, Enigma pulls out the stabilization device and thrusts it up against the core, which now resembles a squash racket.

Now it's a blob of ...

Ulrich: Liquid metal?

Enigma: It could be your brother.

Ulrich: This isn't like that incident with the oscilloscope. I'm one hundred percent certain: this is not an Awakened.

Enigma: Then we'll skip greeting it in every language you know. But since you brought it up—

Enigma: It's possible that it stores encrypted data like the oscilloscope did.

Enigma: Let's go. We'll take it outside and examine it.

Enigma: The core sustains the entire toybox. This can't simply be some mere decorative kaleidoscope.

Laplace

X: Are you certain? I thought it had some tenuous connection to Mr. Ludwig.

???: Your last report stated it was delivered by Madam Z. Don't you worry it may have other purposes?

X: Madam Z has always been interested in "Storm"-related research. It's not surprising she'd ask the Toymaker to bring a "Storm" simulation device.

X: The toybox displays two anomalies: Mr. Ludwig's arcane fluctuation and post-damage symptoms resembling the Language Deviation Syndrome.

X: Given that Mr. Ludwig's field of research involves linguistic analysis, I recommend the headquarters pursue leads through him.

X: Now that the fluctuation inside the box has vanished, the priority should be continuing our search for information related to Mr. Ludwig.

X: Including any intelligence and theories. Of course, I won't conceal anything relevant from the headquarters.

???: Heh, naturally, your reports are always so "timely."

???: I'm simply informing you that the headquarters may make a move soon. Enjoy yourself.

X: Understood.

The young man ends the call. The room falls quiet again, except for the rise and fall of his breath.

The "Storm" has yet to arrive. Besides, a distant hurricane would hardly affect a butterfly at rest here.

He walks out with the same light steps as always.

Enigma's Office

Lucy: I understand that you and Mr. Ulrich have each submitted your own *Pre-Storm Emergency Protocols*. Congratulations on your progress.

Enigma: Thank you. How have you been?

Lucy: I continue to execute my assigned task of "resting" and have collected 38,742 pieces of behavioral data related to this term through various channels.

Lucy: Currently I am practicing these relevant behaviors according to my scheduled itinerary. Based on feedback from those around me, while my execution occasionally deviates, the overall outcome meets expectations.

Lucy: "Call former colleagues during vacation, boast about holiday plans, and relish their work-related complaints" is on today's "resting" checklist. As you might infer, that includes you.

Lucy: Now, please assist me in completing this task by airing any "gripes" or "complaints" you may have.

Enigma: ...

Enigma: You're still so very ... you. How wonderful.

Enigma: How do I put this? I ...

Enigma: I still have zero leads on the toybox core research. Files awaiting approval outnumber Ulrich's remaining vacation days. And Laplace ...

He shakes his head and stops.

Enigma: These are matters I need to handle myself. I shouldn't be complaining to you.

Enigma: Best of luck with your "rest program."

Lucy: I am pleased you approve of my current task.

Madam Lucy nods through the communicator, her artificial eyes observing her former subordinate through the screen.

Lucy: To my knowledge, Laplace has always upheld the highest principles of humanitarianism when it comes to employee welfare.

Lucy: If you are feeling fatigued, you should apply for leave and pursue appropriate rest.

Lucy: I have gained considerable expertise in selecting ideal destinations and recuperation methods. You are welcome to consult with me at any time.

Enigma: ... Thank you.

Enigma: I just might.

The robot blinks cheerfully.

Lucy: Well then, I must prepare for the next item on my list: "Sneak into pre-vacation workplace, execute random pranks, and await the 'moment of surprise.'"

Lucy: Goodbye, Mr. Enigma.

Enigma: Goodbye, Madam Luc—

Enigma: Wait, hold on, don't hang up! What did you just say?!